announced that there would be ‘no compromise’ in accepting ‘Gandhism as the ideology of the new party’, insisting that its economic ideas were closer to Gandhi’s than even the Congress Party’s.[12]

The new party’s emphasis on being inclusive of non-Jan Sangh and non-RSS members was reflected in the fact that non-Sangh luminaries from the Janata Party—like the eminent lawyer Shanti Bhushan, father of the present-day civil rights lawyer Prashant Bhushan; the legal luminary Ram Jethmalani; and the former Congressman Sikandar Bakht—were all given a prominent place on the inauguration dais. Bhushan declared he was convinced that the real ‘Janata’ (the party, but also a play on the word for ‘people’) was represented at the convention.[13] Interestingly, two of the three members in the committee that was tasked with drafting the BJP’s new constitution that day were not from the Sangh: Jethmalani, a Sindhi refugee of Partition, and Bakht, a Delhi Muslim.[14] It was also Bakht who proposed Vajpayee’s name for party president, seconded by the party’s Rajasthan satrap, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat.

As a contemporary account noted, initially, the BJP ‘appeared to play down its Jana Sangh–RSS antecedents to project itself as the standard-bearer of the idealistic and morally high-minded JP movement of the mid-seventies’.[15] The new party, in its first big policy statements, was looking to claim ‘direct descendance from the JP movement and so to stand for the same principles that characterised the movement’. Simultaneously, it seemed to give the impression of ‘wanting to jettison the communalist baggage with which, because of its communal Jana Sangh-RSS associations, it would otherwise be lumbered’.[16]

Essentially, caught between trying to attract a larger group of new voters and seeking to retain its traditional base of those who felt that a Hindu majority should not be apologetic about trying to build a social order on ‘Hindu principles’, the party’s initial public position on the RSS question appeared to reflect a ‘heightened sense of ambivalence’. It seemed to neither ‘wholly repudiate nor unreservedly embrace’ its RSS legacy.[17] The twists and turns on its RSS connection and its stance on Hindu questions suggested, to